

New Old Crocodile Is Missing Its Nose Tip, Just Like the Sphinx

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The Great Sphinx in Egypt is famous for its missing nose. Now scientists have named a new kind of **extinct** crocodile. Its **fossil** skull is missing the tip of its **snout**, too!

The new **species** is called *Herugavialis cairensis*. It was a gavial, a crocodile with a long, thin **snout**. Only two kinds of gavials are alive today. But long ago, they lived all over the world.

The skull was dug up in the 1920s from a 45-million-year-old layer of rock in Egypt. At first, scientists thought it was a crocodile kind that is still alive today. New tools helped them look inside the skull. They found it was a new **species**.

"We decided to name the new crocodile after the Egyptian god Heru," said scientist Philip Mannion. Crocodiles disappeared from the **Mediterranean** area when that sea dried up about 6 million years ago.

Word Treasure

extinct -- No longer alive anywhere on Earth.

fossil -- What is left of a plant or animal from long ago, kept in rock.

species -- A group of living things of the same kind.

snout -- The long nose and mouth part of an animal's face.

Mediterranean -- A large sea between Europe, Africa and Asia.

Background you need

Fossils are the remains of plants and animals from long ago that turned to stone or left marks in rock.

Scientists give each new kind of animal a special two-part name.

The Great Sphinx is a giant statue in Egypt with a lion's body and a human head.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists, including Philip Mannion

WHAT: They named a new extinct crocodile, *Herugavialis cairensis*

WHERE: Its skull was found in rock in Egypt

WHY: New tools showed the old fossil was a new species, and its missing snout tip matched the Sphinx

Why it matters

It shows that old fossils in museums can still hold new surprises for curious scientists.

Test what you remember

1. What is the Great Sphinx famous for missing?

- ☐ (A) Its feet
- ☐ (B) Its nose
- ☐ (C) Its tail
- ☐ (D) Its ears

2. What part of the crocodile fossil is missing?

- ☐ (A) The tip of its snout
- ☐ (B) Its teeth
- ☐ (C) Its tail
- ☐ (D) Its legs

3. What kind of crocodile was it?

- ☐ (A) A gavial with a long, thin snout
- ☐ (B) A flying crocodile
- ☐ (C) A crocodile with no teeth
- ☐ (D) A tiny pet crocodile

4. When was the skull dug up?

- ☐ (A) 6 million years ago
- ☐ (B) In the 1920s
- ☐ (C) In 2020
- ☐ (D) Last week

5. How old is the rock layer the skull came from?

- ☐ (A) 45 years
- ☐ (B) 45 million years
- ☐ (C) 6 billion years
- ☐ (D) 4,500 years

6. Who was the crocodile named after?

- ☐ (A) A pharaoh's pet
- ☐ (B) A scientist
- ☐ (C) The Sphinx's builder
- ☐ (D) The Egyptian god Heru

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: A 4: B 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Philip Mannion: Says the team named the crocodile after the Egyptian god Heru.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):